

US Patent & Trademark Office

Patent Public Search | Text View

United States Patent Application Publication

20250276200

Kind Code

A1

Publication Date

September 04, 2025

Inventor(s)

Sada; Armando

VEHICLE ESCAPE ACCESSORY

Abstract

A vehicle escape accessory has a body sized and shaped to be receivable within a cup holder compartment in the interior of a vehicle. One or more vehicle escape tools are provided in or on the body. A driver or passenger within a vehicle and in need of escaping the vehicle can remove the body from the cup holder compartment and utilize the vehicle escape tool to facilitate escape from the vehicle. In one version, the vehicle escape tool comprises one or both of a window breaking tool and a seatbelt cutting tool.

Inventors: Sada; Armando (San Pedro Garza Garcia, MX)

Applicant: Sada; Armando (San Pedro Garza Garcia, MX)

Family ID: 96387555

Appl. No.: 19/019049

Filed: January 13, 2025

Related U.S. Application Data

us-provisional-application US 63620564 20240112

Publication Classification

Int. Cl.: A62B3/00 (20060101); B26B11/00 (20060101); B60R22/32 (20060101)

U.S. Cl.:

CPC A62B3/00 (20130101); B26B11/00 (20130101); B60R22/32 (20130101); B60R2022/328 (20130101)

Background/Summary

PRIORITY [0001] The present application claims the benefit of domestic priority based on U.S. Provisional Patent Application 63/620,564 filed on Jan. 12, 2024, the entirety of which is incorporated herein by reference.

BACKGROUND

[0002] The fear of being trapped in a vehicle and not being able to get out is a palpable one that almost every driver or passenger has experienced.

[0003] When a vehicle accident happens, sometimes a driver and/or passenger needs to quickly escape the vehicle. In most cases, this is easily done, and a vehicle occupant merely unfastens a seat belt, opens a door, and exits the vehicle either on his or her own or with the assistance of someone else. However, sometimes a vehicle occupant is in a situation where a conventional exit from a vehicle is not possible. For example, a severe accident might cause enough damage to a vehicle that it impedes escapability, such as by damaging a door to such an extent that it will not open or by breaking a seat belt release mechanism or making it unreachable.

[0004] In cases such as these, a trapped person can often use their phone to call for help if there is no one else on the scene. However, sometimes cell phones become displaced or unreachable as a result of the accident, and sometimes accidents happen in locations with poor phone service. Also, there are situations when a trapped occupant does not have the ability to wait until help arrives. For example, sometimes there is smoke, fire, or flood danger necessitating a quick escape. There is also the nightmare scenario of being in a vehicle that has become submerged in water and the doors will not open.

[0005] While the actual scenario of being in a situation where a quick escape is necessary is somewhat rare, the fear of being in these circumstances is real and common. Some individuals are so panic stricken by these thoughts they have recurring dreams or have difficulty driving over bridges or the like.

[0006] There is therefore a need for a way to help a trapped occupant escape a vehicle. There is a further need for a vehicle escape tool to help a trapped occupant escape a vehicle. There is a further need for a vehicle escape tool in the form of an easily reachable accessory. There is a further need for a handy and reliable accessory that can help alleviate the fear of being trapped in a vehicle.

SUMMARY

[0007] The present invention satisfies one or more of these needs. In one aspect of the invention, a tool to help a trapped occupant escape a vehicle is provided.

[0008] In another aspect of the invention, a tool in the form of an easily reachable accessory to help a trapped occupant escape a vehicle is provided.

[0009] In another aspect of the invention, an accessory to help a trapped occupant escape a vehicle is provided in a known and handy location.

[0010] In another aspect of the invention, a vehicle escape accessory is provided, wherein the vehicle escape accessory has other uses.

[0011] In another aspect of the invention, a vehicle escape accessory is provided, wherein the vehicle escape accessory is storable in a cup holder compartment of the vehicle.

[0012] In another aspect of the invention, a vehicle escape accessory is provided, wherein the vehicle escape accessory is insertable into a cup holder of the vehicle.

[0013] In another aspect of the invention, a vehicle escape accessory is provided, wherein the vehicle escape accessory is a structural component of a cup holder of the vehicle.

[0014] In another aspect of the invention, a vehicle escape accessory comprises a body that has an escape tool region that houses, contains, or stores one or more escape tools.

[0015] In another aspect of the invention, a vehicle escape tool comprises an escape tool

compartment located in the bottom portion of a vehicle escape accessory body and an additional accessory region in the top portion.

[0016] In another aspect of the invention, a vehicle escape tool comprises an escape tool compartment located in the bottom portion of a vehicle escape accessory body and an additional accessory region in the top portion, wherein the additional accessory region comprises a coin holder.

[0017] In another aspect of the invention, a vehicle escape tool comprises an escape tool compartment located in the bottom portion of a vehicle escape accessory body, wherein the escape tool compartment houses one or more vehicle escape tools, the vehicle escape tools comprising a window breaking tool, a seatbelt cutting tool, and/or another vehicle escape tool.

[0018] In another aspect of the invention, a vehicle escape tool comprises an escape tool compartment located in the bottom portion of a vehicle escape accessory body and an additional accessory region, wherein the vehicle escape tool is sized and shaped to be received in a cup holder compartment of a vehicle.

[0019] In another aspect of the invention, a vehicle escape tool comprises an escape tool compartment located in the bottom portion of a vehicle escape accessory body and an additional accessory region, wherein the vehicle escape tool is part of a cup holder compartment of a vehicle.

[0020] In another aspect of the invention, a vehicle escape tool comprises and combination of the above or below described features.

[0021] In another aspect of the invention, a method of escaping a vehicle comprises using a vehicle escape accessory including any of the above or below described features or combination thereof.

[0022] In another aspect of the invention, a method of being prepared to escape a vehicle in the event of a need to do so comprises storing a vehicle escape accessory including any of the above or below described features or combination thereof within reach in the interior of a vehicle.

[0023] In another aspect of the invention, a vehicle escape accessory comprises a body sized and shaped to be receivable within a cup holder compartment in the interior of a vehicle; and a vehicle escape tool in or on the body, wherein a driver or passenger within a vehicle and in need of escaping the vehicle can remove the body from the cup holder compartment and utilize the vehicle escape tool to facilitate escape from the vehicle.

[0024] In another aspect of the invention, a vehicle escape accessory comprises a body sized and shaped to be receivable within a cup holder compartment in the interior of a vehicle; and a vehicle escape tool in or on the body, wherein a driver or passenger within a vehicle and in need of escaping the vehicle can remove the body from the cup holder compartment and utilize the vehicle escape tool to facilitate escape from the vehicle, wherein the vehicle escape tool comprises a window breaking tool and/or a seatbelt cutting tool.

[0025] In another aspect of the invention, a vehicle escape accessory comprises a body sized and shaped to be receivable within a cup holder compartment in the interior of a vehicle; and a vehicle escape tool in or on the body, wherein a driver or passenger within a vehicle and in need of escaping the vehicle can remove the body from the cup holder compartment and utilize the vehicle escape tool to facilitate escape from the vehicle, wherein the body comprises an escape tool compartment in a bottom portion of the body, wherein the vehicle escape tool is contained within the escape tool compartment.

[0026] In another aspect of the invention, a vehicle escape accessory comprises a body sized and shaped to be receivable within a cup holder compartment in the interior of a vehicle; a window breaking tool and/or a seatbelt cutting tool in or on the body; and an additional accessory in or on the body, wherein a driver or passenger within a vehicle and in need of escaping the vehicle can remove the body from the cup holder compartment and utilize the vehicle escape tool to facilitate escape from the vehicle.

[0027] In another aspect of the invention, a vehicle escape accessory comprises a body sized and shaped to be receivable within a cup holder compartment in the interior of a vehicle; a window

breaking tool and/or a seatbelt cutting tool in or on the body; and an additional accessory in or on the body, wherein a driver or passenger within a vehicle and in need of escaping the vehicle can remove the body from the cup holder compartment and utilize the vehicle escape tool to facilitate escape from the vehicle, wherein the additional accessory comprises one or more of a coin holder, a cup holder, and a power supply station.

[0028] In another aspect of the invention, a method of escaping a vehicle comprises providing an escape tool accessory in a cup holder compartment in the interior of a vehicle; removing the escape tool accessory from the cup holder when there is a need to escape the vehicle; and using the escape tool accessory to help facilitate escape from the vehicle.

[0029] In another aspect of the invention, a method of escaping a vehicle comprises providing an escape tool accessory in a cup holder compartment in the interior of a vehicle; removing the escape tool accessory from the cup holder when there is a need to escape the vehicle; and using the escape tool accessory to help facilitate escape from the vehicle, where the step of using the escape tool accessory to help facilitate escape from the vehicle comprises using the escape tool accessory to break a window and/or to cut a seatbelt.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0030] These features, aspects, and advantages of the present invention will become better understood with regard to the following description, appended claims, and accompanying drawings which illustrate exemplary features of the invention. However, it is to be understood that each of the features can be used in the invention in general, not merely in the context of the particular drawings, and the invention includes any combination of these features, where:

[0031] FIG. 1A is a schematic perspective view from the front and top of a version of a vehicle escape accessory of the invention;

[0032] FIG. 1B is a schematic top view of the vehicle escape accessory of FIG. 1A;

[0033] FIG. 2A is a schematic perspective view from the side of the vehicle escape accessory of FIG. 1A turned upside down;

[0034] FIG. 2B is a schematic perspective view from the front of the vehicle escape accessory of FIG. 2A;

[0035] FIG. 3 is a schematic perspective view of the vehicle escape accessory being positioned in the interior of a vehicle;

[0036] FIG. 4A is a schematic perspective view from the front and top of another version of a vehicle escape accessory of the invention;

[0037] FIG. 4B is a schematic perspective view from the front and top of another version of a vehicle escape accessory of the invention;

[0038] FIG. 4C is a schematic perspective view from the front and top of another version of a vehicle escape accessory of the invention;

[0039] FIG. 5A is a schematic perspective view from the front and top of another version of a vehicle escape accessory of the invention;

[0040] FIG. 5B is a schematic top view of the vehicle escape accessory of FIG. 5A;

[0041] FIG. 6A is a schematic perspective view from the front and top of another version of a vehicle escape accessory of the invention;

[0042] FIG. 6B is a schematic perspective view from the front and top of another version of a vehicle escape accessory of the invention;

[0043] FIG. 7 is a schematic perspective view from the front and top of another version of a vehicle escape accessory of the invention; and

[0044] FIG. 8 is a schematic perspective view from the front and top of another version of a vehicle

escape accessory of the invention with a portion of the vehicle escape accessory being shown as a phantom.

DESCRIPTION

[0045] The present invention relates to a vehicle accessory. In particular, the invention relates to a vehicle accessory useful for helping a trapped occupant escape a vehicle. Although the vehicle accessory is illustrated and described in the context of being useful for helping escape, the present invention can be useful in other instances. Accordingly, the present invention is not intended to be limited to the examples and embodiments described herein.

[0046] FIGS. 1A, 1B, 2A, 2B, 3, 4A through 4C, 5A, 5B, 6A, 6B, 7, and 8 show versions of a vehicle escape accessory **100** according to the invention. The vehicle escape accessory comprises a body **105** that has an escape tool region **110** that houses, contains, or stores one or more escape tools **115**. By accessory it is meant any feature or element in or on a vehicle that is not directly associated with the driving operation of the vehicle. Accessories may come pre-installed in a vehicle or may be separately purchased. Accessories may be permanently housed in or on the vehicle, may be placed and housed in or on a permanent feature of the vehicle, may be come with a manner of attachment that allows the accessory to be attached to a location in or on the vehicle, or may simply reside somewhere in or on the vehicle, such as by sitting in a compartment in the vehicle. By escape tool it is meant any tool or implement that is designed to help facilitate the escape of a trapped vehicle occupant in some manner. By vehicle it is meant any type of vehicle capable of containing or carrying one or more individuals and capable or being driven directly, indirectly, remotely, autonomously, or the like, and includes by way of non-exhaustive examples an automobile, a car, a truck, a van, an SUV, an ATV, a tractor, a tractor trailer, a bus, an ambulance, a firetruck, a mail delivery vehicle, a military vehicle, a rescue vehicle, a recreational motor home, an executive motor coach, and the like.

[0047] One version of a vehicle escape accessory **100** is shown in FIGS. 1A and 1B. In this version, the escape tool region **110** of the body **105** of the vehicle escape accessory **100** is an escape tool compartment **120** located in the bottom portion **125** of the vehicle escape accessory body **105**. Alternatively, the escape tool region **110** can be positioned at any other position on the body **105**, such as the top or the side. As shown in the version of FIGS. 1A and 1B, the vehicle escape accessory **100** can also include an additional accessory region **130** which in this version is provided in the top portion **135** of the vehicle escape accessory **100**. The additional accessory region **130** can comprise an additional accessory **140**, such as an accessory that would be useful for a vehicle driver or other occupant while in the vehicle. For example, in the version of FIGS. 1A and 1B, the additional accessory **140** comprises a coin holder **145** which includes one or more coin slots **150** that can be sized and shaped to contain coins so that the coins are easily accessible to the driver or other occupant. In the particular version shown, the one or more coin slots **150** include different sized slots sized and shaped to hold different sized coins. The additional accessory **140** can also or alternatively include an optional storage compartment **155** that can hold various objects that the driver or occupant might need to access while in the vehicle. Optionally, indicia **160** can be provided to provide an indication of the number of coins in a coin slot **150**.

[0048] FIGS. 2A and 2B show the vehicle escape accessory **100** of FIGS. 1A and 1B turned upside down so that the bottom portion **125** and the escape tool region **110** can be viewed. Within the escape tool region **110** is one or more vehicle escape tools **115**. The one or more vehicle escape tools **115** can be any tool that could be useful in helping a vehicle occupant escape a vehicle if and when the need arises. For example, in the version shown, the vehicle escape tool **115** comprise one or more of a window breaking tool **205** and/or a seatbelt cutting tool **210**.

[0049] The window breaking tool **205** of the vehicle escape accessory **100** is designed to break tempered glass windows such as those commonly found in vehicles. The window breaking tool includes a tip member **215** made of hard material, such as one or more of steel, tungsten carbide, ceramic, diamond, and the like that is shaped to form a point **220** designed to make it easier to

cause a window to break when the tip member **215** is advanced quickly at the window so that the window is struck with force by the point **220**. A tip member **215** of the type shown in FIGS. 2A and 2B are commonly found on emergency hammer devices, also known as bus mallets, dotty hammers, safety mallets, and bus hammers.

[0050] In use, a user such as a vehicle driver or other occupant would grasp the vehicle escape accessory **100** and would quickly advance the bottom portion **125** at the window to be broken so that the point **220** of the tip member **215** contacts the window with enough force to cause the window to break. A tempered window will shatter when struck with the tip member **215** with sufficient force. The force can either be generated by the manual advancement of the vehicle escape accessory **100** by the user or a spring mechanism can be provided to spring load the tip member **215** to assist in the delivery of force.

[0051] The one or more safety tools **115** can alternatively or additionally include one or more seatbelt cutting tools **210**. The seatbelt cutting tool **210** includes a blade **225**, as seen in FIG. 2B, provided in a blade slot **230** of a blade receiving member **235**. The blade receiving member **235** also includes a transversely extending seatbelt slot **240** that is sized and shaped to receive the strap of a seatbelt so that the strap of a seatbelt can be slid into the seatbelt slot **240** so that it can contact the blade **225** in the blade slot **230** in a manner that will allow the blade **225** to cut the strap. A user can use the seatbelt cutting tool **210** to cut a seatbelt that is otherwise difficult or impossible to disengage and that is trapping a vehicle occupant. The blade **225** can be used to slice the entire way through the strap or can be used to start a slice in the strap so that the strap can be forced apart. The blade **225** can be removeably or permanently positioned within the blade slot **230**. In the particular version shown, a blade securing mechanism **245** is provided that includes one or more blade securing members **250** that allow the blade **225** to be replaceably contained within the blade slot **230**. For example, the one or more blade securing members **250** can comprise a screw or bolt that extends through a hole in the blade **225** or can be a set screw that contacts the blade **225** to hold it by friction, or the like. The blade **225** and blade receiving member **235** can be moved and/or oriented to any other position within compartment **120** or elsewhere in or on the body **105**.

[0052] In the version of FIGS. 2A and 2B, the bottom portion **125** includes an escape tool compartment **120** that houses and at least partially surrounds the one or more vehicle escape tools **200**. The escape tool compartment **120** is defined by a base **255** that provides a platform for the one or more escape tools **115** and one or more side walls **260** that extend from the base **255** and at least partially enclose the one or more vehicle escape tools **115**. In the version shown, the side walls **260** have an end, such as a bottom edge **265**, that form a surface on the vehicle escape accessory **100** can at least partially rest. In that regard, the side walls **260** can be sufficiently strong and rigid to be able to support the weight of the vehicle escape accessory **100** when oriented as shown in FIGS. 1A and 1B and placed on a surface.

[0053] When the one or more vehicle escape tools **115** comprises a window breaking tool **205**, the side wall **260** can also be sufficiently weak, that it breaks or collapses when the window breaking tool **205** is advanced towards the window to be broken. For example, when swung at the window, the bottom edge **265** of the side wall **260** can contact the window before tip member **215**, and the contact can break off the side wall **260** so that the tip member **215** can then advance and contact the window in either the same or a subsequent strike. Alternatively, the user can hit the side wall **260** against a hard object to break off the side wall **260** before swinging the tip member **215** at the window. Alternatively, the user can break off the side wall **260** by hand. Optionally, a scoring or otherwise weakened portion can be provided to make the breaking of the side wall **260** easier. In another version, there is no side wall **260** provided or the side wall **260** does not extend to an extent where it would interfere with the tip member **215** operation.

[0054] When the one or more vehicle escape tools **115** comprises a seatbelt cutting tool **210**, the side wall **260** can be provided with one or more side wall slots **270**. The one or more side wall slots **270** are adapted to receive the seat belt strap that is to be cut and can be positioned in alignment

with the seatbelt slot **240**. Alternatively, the seatbelt slot **240** can be incorporated into the side wall **260** so that the side wall slot **270** serves as the seatbelt slot **240**. In either case, the slots can be oriented parallel to the longitudinal axis of the vehicle escape accessory **100** and/or the up and down direction and/or the direction of the tip member **215** if provided. Alternatively, the slots can be provided at an angle relative to any of those axes. In one version, a seatbelt cutting tool **210** can be provided at each of the side wall slots **270** with one or more blades associated with each of the two or more slots to make it easier for the user to determine which slot has the cutting capabilities. [0055] In one version, as shown in FIG. 3, the vehicle escape accessory **100** is designed to be stored, positioned, or held in a cup holder compartment **300** or other compartment, such as a storage compartment or ashtray compartment, in the interior **305** of a vehicle. Most vehicle interiors **305** include one or more cup holder compartments **300** that are designed to hold a cup or drinking container for a driver or other occupant of the vehicle. The purpose of the cup holder compartment **300** is to position a cup or other item within convenient and easy reach of the user and in a known location. By placing the vehicle escape accessory **100** within the cup holder compartment **300**, the vehicle escape accessory **100** then too will be within easy reach of the user and at a known location. In the event of being trapped in a vehicle, a user would then have easy access to the vehicle escape tools **200** within the vehicle escape accessory **100** and would not have to fumble around looking for the tools or having the think about where they are located. This is particularly helpful when there has been an accident that affects the mental condition and/or wherewithal of the occupant in need of escape. To use the vehicle escape accessory **100** of the version of FIG. 3, a user would merely reach to the cup holder compartment, pull out the vehicle escape accessory **100** and orient it for either cutting a seatbelt, breaking a window, or otherwise assisting in the escape from being trapped in the vehicle.

[0056] In the version of FIG. 3, the body **105** of the vehicle escape accessory **100** is sized and shaped to be receivable within a standard size cup holder compartment **300** so that the vehicle escape accessory **100** or at least a portion thereof can be slid in and out of the cup holder compartment **300**. When in place and when the vehicle is in normal use, the vehicle escape accessory **100** is stored within the cup holder compartment **300** and the escape tool region **110** is hidden from view and unnoticeable. If the vehicle escape accessory **100** has an additional accessory **140**, such as the coin holder **145** as shown in FIG. 3, then the additional accessory **140** functions in its normal capacity until there is a need to remove the vehicle escape accessory **100** to use the one or more escape tools **115**.

[0057] In one version, the vehicle escape accessory **100** comes as an after-market, separately purchaseable accessory that is sized and shaped to fit most conventionally sized and shaped cup holder compartments **300**. In one version, the vehicle escape accessory **100** can be screwed into a cup holder or cup. Alternatively, the vehicle escape accessory **100** can be custom-fit to fit snugly within a particular cup holder accessory. Alternatively, the body **105** of the vehicle escape accessory **100** can be sized and shaped to fit into a different storage compartment **310** that is not designed to be a cup holder.

[0058] In another version, the vehicle escape accessory **100** comes as an integral part of the vehicle interior **305**. For example, the vehicle manufacturer can use the space associated with a cup holder compartment **300** or a different compartment **310** and adapt the vehicle escape accessory **100** to fit within that space. In one particular version, the vehicle escape accessory **100** can be contoured and shaped to match the contour and the vehicle interior **305** so that it becomes a substantially seamless part of the vehicle interior **305**.

[0059] FIGS. 4A, 4B, and 4C show other examples of additional accessory **140**

[0060] possibilities for the vehicle escape accessory **100**. FIG. 4A shows a different type of coin holder **145** with coin slots **150** that include a biased platform **405** that urge the coins to the top of the coin slot **150**. FIG. 4B shows a coin holder **145** similar to the one in FIGS. 1A and 1B but with a storage compartment **155** sufficiently deep to be able to hold pencils and/or other implements,

such as a cell phone. FIG. 4C shows a version of the vehicle escape accessory **100** where the additional accessory **140** is a power supply and/or charging station **410**, which can also include a slot for holding a cell phone. In another version, the additional accessory can be a cell phone holder. In another version, a combination of the features of FIGS. 4A, 4B, and/or 4C can be provided, such by having a vehicle escape accessory that is a combination coin holder and charger. In another version, the additional accessory **140** is an ashtray.

[0061] FIGS. 5A and 5B show a version of a vehicle escape accessory **100** where the additional accessory is a cup holder **500**. In this version, the body **105** of the vehicle escape accessory **100** is sized and shaped to fit in a cup holder compartment **300** of a vehicle interior **305**. The body **105** also has a top portion **135** with a cup holder side wall **505** and lower surface **510** that defines an interior space **515** that is sized and shaped to contain a cup or other beverage container.

Accordingly, this version of the vehicle escape accessory **100** operates as a cup holder insert into a cup holder compartment **300**. The side wall **505** thus mimics the cup holder compartment **300** of the vehicle and allows the space to continue to be used as a cup holder but with one or more escape tools hidden in the bottom of the insert. This insert can be provided as a separately purchased insert or can be an integral part of the cup holder compartment **300** provided by the manufacturers or after-market provider. In another version, the vehicle escape accessory **100** can be in the form of an actual cup that is adapted to hold a beverage, the cup being sized and shaped to be received within the cup holder compartment **300**. The cup can be provided with or without additional features, such as a handle and/or a lid.

[0062] FIG. 6A shows a version of a vehicle escape accessory **100** similar to the version of FIGS. 1A and 1B. However, in this version, a padding **605** or the like is provided on the top **610** of the vehicle escape accessory **100** to help soften the impact on a user's hand if the user uses the top **610** to apply the window breaking force.

[0063] FIG. 6B shows a version of a vehicle escape accessory that does not include an additional accessory **140**. In the particular version shown, the entire top portion **135** of the body **105** of the vehicle escape accessory **100** is removed. This version is particularly useful as an insert that can be inserted and/or stored in the bottom of a cup holder compartment **300** or different compartment **310** in the vehicle interior **305**. In this version, a flat top **615** can be provided that will mimic the bottom of the cup holder compartment **300** or different compartment **310** so that a cup or other object can be stored in the compartment. When a user need to access the one or more escape tools **115**, the user removes any cup or other object that is resting on the flat top **605** and removes the vehicle escape accessory **100** from the compartment. Optionally, a graspable member **620** or handle can be provided to help remove the vehicle escape accessory **100** from the compartment. In one version, the graspable member **620** can be screwed onto an item such as a cup or coin holder.

[0064] Another version of a vehicle escape accessory **100** is shown in FIG. 7. In this version, the escape tool region **110** of the body **105** of the vehicle escape accessory **100** is alternatively or additionally provided on at a position other than the bottom portion **125** of the body **105**. In the version shown, the escape tool region **110** is on a side surface region **705** of the escape accessory body **105**. In the version shown, the escape tool region comprises both the side surface region **705** and an escape tool compartment **120** located in the bottom portion **125** of the vehicle escape accessory body **105**. In the particular version shown, the vehicle escape accessory comprises a window breaking tool **205** in the bottom compartment, as shown for example, in FIGS. 2A and 2B, and a seatbelt cutting tool **210** on the side surface **705**. In this version, the seatbelt cutting tool includes an outwardly extending member **710** that extends from an outer side surface **715** of the vehicle escape accessory body **105**. A seatbelt cutting blade **225** is contained within a seatbelt receiving slot **720** within the outwardly extending member **710**. In use, a user can grasp the vehicle escape accessory **100** and manipulate it so that a seatbelt in need of being cut is received within the slot **720** in a manner where the blade **225** can cut the seatbelt. The outwardly extending member can also serve as a handle for the vehicle escape accessory **100**. In another version, both the

window breaking tool **205** and the seatbelt cutting tool **210** are in the top portion **135** or side surface region **705**. In another version, the seatbelt cutting tool **210** is in the bottom portion **125** and the window breaking tool **205** is on a side surface region **705** or on the top portion **135**.

[0065] The vehicle escape accessory **100** of FIG. 7 can be inserted and/or stored within a cup holder compartment **300** or other conveniently reachable area of the vehicle as discussed above. The vehicle escape accessory can be designed to fit within a circular cupholder **300** or a U-shaped slot can be provided in the cupholder **300** to accommodate the outwardly extending member **710**. FIG. 8 shows a version where the vehicle escape accessory **100** of FIG. 7 is storable in an accessory holder **800** that has a lower space **805** sized and/or shaped to contain the vehicle escape accessory **100**, such as the vehicle escape accessory **100** of FIG. 7 or any other version described herein, and an upper space **810** that can receive a cup or the like. The accessory holder **800** can be a permanent or integral part of the vehicle interior **305** or can be removeably receiveable in a cupholder compartment **300** of the vehicle. The accessory holder **800** can also optionally be provided with a U-shaped slot of the like for accommodating the outwardly extending member **710**. Alternatively or additionally, the accessory holder **800** can have an upper space **810** or other region designed to hold a phone or other item and/or can be a power supply station.

[0066] The vehicle escape accessory **100** of the present invention thus provides easy and convenient access to escape tools **115** when needed. In addition, the vehicle escape accessory **100** positions the escape tools in a known location so that a user does not have to try to remember where the tools are located. This is not only useful in the rare instances when they might be needed, but the vehicle escape accessory **100** provides peace of mind for the vehicle occupant who might otherwise worry and/or have a fear of becoming trapped in a vehicle.

[0067] Though described as being useful for providing easy and convenient access to one or more vehicle escape tools **115**, the vehicle escape accessory **100** can serve additional or alternative purposes. For example, the escape tool compartment **120** can be used as a secretive storage compartment for storing private items or money. The escape tool compartment **120** can also be used to store tools other than those that are specifically designed to assist with escaping a trapped situation, such as a flashlight, screwdriver, car repair tools, phone, phone holder, phone charger, battery charger, usb cable, electric outlet or adapter, and the like.

[0068] Although the present invention has been described in considerable detail with regard to certain preferred versions thereof, other versions are possible, and alterations, permutations and equivalents of the versions shown will become apparent to those skilled in the art upon a reading of the specification and study of the drawings. For example, the cooperating components may be reversed or provided in additional or fewer number, and all directional limitations, such as up and down and the like, can be switched, reversed, or changed as long as doing so is not prohibited by the language herein with regard to a particular version of the invention. Like numerals represent like parts from figure to figure. When the same reference number has been used in multiple figures, the discussion associated with that reference number in one figure is intended to be applicable to the additional figure(s) in which it is used, so long as doing so is not prohibited by explicit language with reference to one of the figures. Also, the various features of the versions herein can be combined in various ways to provide additional versions of the present invention. Furthermore, certain terminology has been used for the purposes of descriptive clarity, and not to limit the present invention. Throughout this specification and any claims appended hereto, unless the context makes it clear otherwise, the term “comprise” and its variations such as “comprises” and “comprising” should be understood to imply the inclusion of a stated element, limitation, or step but not the exclusion of any other elements, limitations, or steps. Throughout this specification and any claims appended hereto, unless the context makes it clear otherwise, the term “consisting of” and “consisting essentially of” should be understood to imply the inclusion of a stated element, limitation, or step and the exclusion of any other elements, limitations, or steps or the exclusion of any other essential elements, limitations, or steps, respectively. Throughout the specification, any

discussion of a combination of elements, limitations, or steps should be understood to include (i) each element, limitation, or step of the combination alone, (ii) each element, limitation, or step of the combination with any one or more other element, limitation, or step of the combination, (iii) an inclusion of additional elements, limitations, or steps (i.e. the combination may comprise one or more additional elements, limitations, or steps), and/or (iv) an exclusion of additional elements, limitations, or steps or an exclusion of essential additional elements, limitations, or steps (i.e. the combination may consist of or consist essentially of the disclosed combination or parts of the combination). All numerical values, unless otherwise made clear in the disclosure or prosecution, include either the exact value or approximations in the vicinity of the stated numerical values, such as for example about $\pm$ ten percent or as would be recognized by a person of ordinary skill in the art in the disclosed context. The same is true for the use of the terms such as about, substantially, and the like. Also, for any numerical ranges given, unless otherwise made clear in the disclosure, during prosecution, or by being explicitly set forth in a claim, the ranges include either the exact range or approximations in the vicinity of the values at one or both of the ends of the range. When multiple ranges are provided, the disclosed ranges are intended to include any combinations of ends of the ranges with one another and including zero and infinity as possible ends of the ranges. Therefore, any appended or later filed claims should not be limited to the description of the preferred versions contained herein and should include all such alterations, permutations, and equivalents as fall within the true spirit and scope of the present invention.

Claims

1. A vehicle escape accessory comprising: a body sized and shaped to be receivable within a cup holder compartment in the interior of a vehicle; and a vehicle escape tool in or on the body, wherein a driver or passenger within a vehicle and in need of escaping the vehicle can remove the body from the cup holder compartment and utilize the vehicle escape tool to facilitate escape from the vehicle.
2. A vehicle escape accessory according to claim 1 wherein the vehicle escape tool comprises a window breaking tool.
3. A vehicle escape accessory according to claim 1 wherein the vehicle escape tool comprises a seatbelt cutting tool.
4. A vehicle escape accessory according to claim 1 wherein the vehicle escape tool is a first vehicle escape tool and wherein a second vehicle escape tool is provided in or on the body.
5. A vehicle escape accessory according to claim 1 wherein the vehicle escape tool comprises a window breaking tool and wherein the vehicle escape tool further comprises a seatbelt cutting tool in or on the body.
6. A vehicle escape accessory according to claim 1 wherein the body comprises an escape tool compartment in a bottom portion of the body, wherein the vehicle escape tool is contained within the escape tool compartment.
7. A vehicle escape accessory according to claim 6 wherein the vehicle escape tool is a window breaking tool.
8. A vehicle escape accessory according to claim 6 wherein the vehicle escape tool is a window breaking tool and wherein a seatbelt cutting tool is also provided in the escape tool compartment.
9. A vehicle escape accessory according to claim 6 wherein the vehicle escape tool is a window breaking tool and wherein a seatbelt cutting tool is also provided in or on the body.
10. A vehicle escape accessory according to claim 1 wherein the body comprises an additional accessory.
11. A vehicle escape accessory according to claim 10 wherein the additional accessory is a coin holder.
12. A vehicle escape accessory according to claim 10 wherein the additional accessory is a cup

holder.

13. A vehicle escape accessory according to claim 10 wherein the additional accessory is a power supply station.

14. A vehicle escape accessory comprising: a body sized and shaped to be receivable within a cup holder compartment in the interior of a vehicle; a window breaking tool or a seatbelt cutting tool in or on the body; and an additional accessory in or on the body, wherein a driver or passenger within a vehicle and in need of escaping the vehicle can remove the body from the cup holder compartment and utilize the vehicle escape tool to facilitate escape from the vehicle.

15. A vehicle escape accessory according to claim 14 wherein the vehicle escape accessory comprises a window breaking tool and a seatbelt cutting tool.

16. A vehicle escape accessory according to claim 14 wherein the additional accessory comprises one or more of a coin holder, a cup holder, and a power supply station.

17. A vehicle escape accessory according to claim 14 wherein the window breaking tool or the seatbelt cutting tool is within an escape tool compartment in a bottom portion of the body and wherein the additional accessory is in a top portion of the body.

18. A method of escaping a vehicle, the method comprising: providing an escape tool accessory in a cup holder compartment in the interior of a vehicle; removing the escape tool accessory from the cup holder when there is a need to escape the vehicle; and using the escape tool accessory to help facilitate escape from the vehicle.

19. A method according to claim 18 wherein the step of using the escape tool accessory to help facilitate escape from the vehicle comprises using the escape tool accessory to break a window.

20. A method according to claim 18 wherein the step of using the escape tool accessory to help facilitate escape from the vehicle comprises using the escape tool accessory to cut a seatbelt.
